

Notes on *Notes from the Underground**

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A tremendous amount of work has been devoted to examining Dostoevsky's life, philosophy, and writing, and in particular to *Notes from Underground*¹. Here, I recall what I wrote in the preface and give a few additional comment.

Notes in Preface

Lens: Human Outlier Analysis (Foucault – “Madness and Civilization”)

Our first story, *Notes from the Underground* by Fyodor Dostoevsky, takes place at a time I am pegging as the start of the “**modern age**.” The story was first published in Russian in 1864 and takes place in Petersburg around 1862–1864, as the American Civil War is raging and as people in Russia are struggling with whether and how to absorb the lessons of the Western Enlightenment.

The unnamed protagonist of the story, often referred to as Dostoevsky's Underground Man, is in many ways an antihero. What he is defying seems to be the Enlightenment itself, and its concomitant notions of what is considered sane and acceptable. Many of us today might see the Underground Man as crazy in his verbose rambling and perverse actions. He may seem preposterous and confused, but do we lose something important if he is ostracized as a mental defective?

If we try to understand the Underground Man, perhaps we can better understand our fellow citizens today who seem to want to roll back to a time before Enlightenment values. Perhaps we can learn to recognize that they have important insight, even as we may view them as crazy.

One tool we will introduce could be called human outlier analysis².

*The title “Notes from the Underground” has also been translated as “Notes from Underground” and “Notes from a Mouse-hole”.

¹A description of the effect on Dostoevsky of his mock execution and exile to Siberia is given in [Dostoevski Is Exiled to Siberia](#). [This is downloaded from [here](#).]

Here are links to series of lectures on the philosophy of *Notes from Underground*, by Gregory B. Sadler, “That Philosophy Guy”:

- [Notes From Underground | Existentialist Philosophy & Literature](#), YouTube 1:01:12
 - Here is a (computer generated) transcript of above, divided into sections.
- [Notes From Underground | Intellectuals Inertia and Negativity | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 17:26
- [Notes From Underground | Pleasure, Perversity, and Suffering | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 16:06
- [Notes From Underground | Revenge, Anger, and Justice | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 19:41
- [Notes From Underground | Desire and Reason | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 17:59
- [Notes From Underground | Self-Interest and the Advantageous | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 14:25
- [Notes From Underground | The Most Advantageous Advantage | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 18:23
- [Notes From Underground | Enlightenment, Laws of Nature, and The Will | Core Concepts](#), YouTube 16:14

²On human outlier analysis, see:

We will ask questions about the Underground Man that could well be asked of ourselves and those around us:

- *How is the protagonist unusual in the society they live, and how are they trying to influence society?*
- *Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?*
- *Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?*
- *What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?*

Additional Notes

- author and his time
 - quick bio
 - early novellette by Dostoyevsky
 - early existentialism : deep psychological exploration, not like fairly simple man against oppression tales we will see later
- themes in story -so many human elements of literature and drama.
 - i'm happy to discuss, but focus here is on "Tales of Defiance to Mind Control"
 - UM reacting to "Crystal Palace" , against 2+2 =4 rationalism
 - * point: most advantageous advantage
 - * ironic that UM against rationalism, even while trapped in it
 - theme throughout Dostoyevsky's works: cave or rational egoism
 - * either you stay in it (sad fate)
 - * or you get salvation through love and faith
 - * UM is too far gone and wrapped in ego to accept love
 - apart from unpublished ending to NFU with salvation
 - * This is direct precursor to "Crime and Punishment", which has twisted rational egoist, who then get salvation through love, leading him to faith
 - * cave of rational egoism is parallel to Plato's cave ("Through a Glass Darkly" footnote – what does that say about religious mind control?)
 - outlier lens:
 - * underground man doesn't fit in -> madness separated from civilization
 - * he is wannabe intellectual

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- *Madness and Civilization* by Michel Foucault, 1961.

This posits that a phenomenon of the Age of Reason is the attempt to eliminate the irrational from philosophical discourse. Institutions (such as hospitals and prisons) were developed to outcast radical thinkers as mad or criminal.